

Fostering public sector employees' citizen-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors through human resource flexibility and employee perceptions of normative public values

Personnel Review

2087

Received 2 February 2022

Revised 30 May 2023

8 February 2024

Accepted 11 April 2024

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Abstract

Purpose – Public sector employees' contributions play a crucial role in improving public service quality and promoting the image of public organizations. The aim of this research is to unravel how and when human resource (HR) flexibility activates citizen-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors among public sector employees.

Design/methodology/approach – The data were collected from 427 public sector employees and 102 supervisors working for governmental agencies from the districts of a major city in Vietnam. Multilevel structural equation modeling (MSEM) was employed to analyze the data.

Findings – The positive associations between HR flexibility and the three dimensions of citizen-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors were supported. Harmonious passion demonstrated a mediating path for such linkages. Employee perceptions of normative public values were found to exert a positive moderating effect on the positive link between HR flexibility and harmonious passion, as well as their indirect link via harmonious passion.

Originality/value – This study advances the literature by identifying how and when HR flexibility shapes citizen-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors among public sector employees.

Keywords Citizen-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors, HR flexibility, Harmonious passion, Employee perceptions of normative public values

Paper type Research paper

Introduction

Growing attention from academics and practitioners has been given to the role of public sector employees in engaging citizen-oriented behaviors to deliver, improve and promote public services (Tantivejakul, 2019). From Bettencourt *et al.*'s (2005) view, citizen-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors can be defined as individuals' prosocial behaviors in forms of internal influence, external representation and service delivery. To fulfill a boundary-spanning role, organizational members can undertake internal influence behavior by generating and sharing initiatives, and influencing colleagues to generate initiatives to improve services (Bayighomog and Arashi, 2019; Bettencourt *et al.*, 2005). Moreover, employees can engage in external representation by representing the public organization to citizens and enhancing citizens' awareness and advocacy of its image (Waymer, 2013). Public sector employees can also achieve their boundary-spanning role by demonstrating responsiveness and courtesy in service delivery, which contribute to augmenting citizens' satisfaction (Nor *et al.*, 2021).



Personnel Review
Vol. 53 No. 8, 2024
pp. 2087-2108

© Emerald Publishing Limited
0048-3486
DOI 10.1108/PR-02-2022-0078

Conflict of interest: Authors declare that they have no conflict of interest.

Due to the importance of citizen-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors in improving the quality of public services (Van Meerkerk and Edelenbos, 2021; Waymer, 2013), it is crucial to explore its antecedents. de Geus *et al.*'s (2020) systematic review of public sector employees' citizenship behaviors revealed a gap in studies of this stream that have focused more on individual antecedents than on contextual ones. Research also indicated that contextual antecedents of citizenship behaviors tend to include leadership and organizational justice (de Geus *et al.*, 2020; Hassan *et al.*, 2017; Tran, 2023) and suggested further inquiries into its contextual determinants. The current study bridges such a gap by considering the antecedent role of human resource management (HRM) for citizen-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors as managing human resources (HRs) is one of the crucial ways to foster citizen-oriented behaviors (Bentein *et al.*, 2021). Since improving customer services necessitates employees' broad set of skills and behavioral scripts for adaptation and flexibility (Übeda-García *et al.*, 2017), research has considered the concept of HR flexibility to explicate partly how organizations can manage changing customer needs (Chang *et al.*, 2013; Luu, 2016). HR flexibility indicates the degree to which an organization's HRs (employees) possess a repertoire of skills and behavioral scripts, and its HR practices can effectively enable those employees to be adaptive (Way *et al.*, 2015).

Despite the potential role of HR flexibility in fostering client-oriented behaviors, as earlier discussed (Chang *et al.*, 2013; Luu, 2016), research regarding the relationship HRM and customer-oriented behavior remains rather quiet about this role of HR flexibility. Insights into this antecedent effect of HR flexibility are further important since they complement prior studies that have concentrated on the role of HR practices in promoting citizenship behaviors through enhancing employee commitment (e.g. high-commitment HR practices) (Chen *et al.*, 2017), job involvement (e.g. high-involvement HR practices) (Yasir and Majid, 2020) or high performance (e.g. high-performance work systems [HPWSs]) (Jaiswal and Tyagi, 2020). In addressing this gap, this study aims to unfold the role of HR flexibility in nurturing citizen-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors among public sector employees. Drawing on the self-determination theory (SDT) (Deci and Ryan, 2014), a social environment that can activate individuals' psychological needs, particularly for autonomy, competence and relatedness, can shape their actions (Deci and Ryan, 2014). Thus, HR flexibility, which can equip employees with skill flexibility, behavioral flexibility and opportunities to use a broad set of skills and behavioral scripts in working with others and having control over work (Way *et al.*, 2015), can fulfill such needs among public sector employees and drive them to achieve their boundary-spanning role. It is crucial to understand the relationship between HR flexibility and citizen-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors since this encourages public sector practitioners to build HR practices that can enable employees to develop a broad set of skills and behavioral scripts necessary for performing new or different work activities and improving public services.

The SDT further contends that a social context that can fulfill individuals' needs for autonomy, competence and relatedness can shape employees' motivation to autonomously internalize activities (Deci and Ryan, 2014; Vallerand *et al.*, 2003). Accordingly, as earlier discussed, HR flexibility, which provides employees with opportunities to satisfy such needs, may stimulate employees to internalize work activities autonomously and develop harmonious passion, which is defined as autonomous internalization that drives an individual to willingly undertake an activity (Vallerand *et al.*, 2003). Moreover, passion has been reported to link some types of HR practices to employee behaviors such as innovative work behavior (Jan *et al.*, 2021) or proactive service performance (Chen *et al.*, 2017). These empirical proofs together with the SDT lens indicate the salience of examining harmonious passion as a mediation mechanism between HR flexibility and citizen-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors. Investigating the mediating role of this form of autonomous internalization, the current study can also complement previous studies that have largely

delted into mediation mechanisms such as work engagement (Bal and De Lange, 2015), self-efficacy (Luu, 2016) and employability (Xu *et al.*, 2023) for the effects of flexibility HRM systems.

Furthermore, in light of the SDT, the impact of a situation on employee motivation can be contingent on contextual or individual factors (Ryan and Deci, 2000). Among individual contingencies, values are salient contingencies highlighted in the SDT (Graves and Sarkis, 2018) but have been given less attention (Park *et al.*, 2018; Sun *et al.*, 2023). The SDT posits that, in the face of a specific organizational situation (e.g. HR practices), different values may affect the process of stimulating employee motivation (Graves and Sarkis, 2018). Research has reported the potentiality of values in leveraging employees' perceptions of contextual factors (e.g. HR practices and leadership), which further strengthens the impact of such factors (Park *et al.*, 2018; Sun *et al.*, 2023). These suggest the potential moderating effect of values on the influence of HR practices on employee outcomes. We, hence, postulate that employee perceptions of normative public values in the work environment may serve as a moderator that influences employee responsiveness to and reliance on HR flexibility, which may further fuel their harmonious passion. Normative public values consist of individual rights (civil rights), representation (responsiveness to all citizens) and equity (fair distribution of resources) (Pandey *et al.*, 2016). Guided by normative public values, employees are more inclined to contribute to the public mission (Pandey *et al.*, 2016), which further influences them to rely on HR flexibility and channel skill and behavioral flexibility into harmonious passion for serving citizens. By unpacking the moderating role of employee perceptions of normative public values for the effect of HR flexibility, our study extends the literature that has scarcely examined the role of normative public values as well as largely focused on moderation mechanisms such as psychological capital (Cheewakoset *et al.*, 2023), organizational identity (Xu *et al.*, 2023) or inclusive leadership (Zhang *et al.*, 2023) underlying the effects of flexibility HRM systems.

In a nutshell, this study develops and validates a research model, in which HR flexibility influences public sector employees' citizen-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors through the mediating path of harmonious passion, as well as employee perceptions of normative public values play a moderating role for such an effect. This research model contributes to the extant literature in some respects. First, by unpacking the link between HR flexibility and citizen-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors among public sector employees, our research answers the calls of researchers to unravel more contextual factors that shape public sector employees' citizen-oriented behaviors (Bentein *et al.*, 2021). Second, our study extends the relationship between HRM and customer-oriented behavior literature by unfolding the mediation path of harmonious passion that links HR flexibility to the citizen-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors. Third, by examining the role of employee perceptions of normative public values as a contingent condition, our study advances our understanding of conditions through which HR flexibility can be optimally utilized in the workplace.

Literature review and hypothesis development

Theoretical basis of the SDT

The SDT focuses on fundamental human needs (competence, autonomy and relatedness), motivations and integrated regulation that underpin one's choices (Deci and Ryan, 2014; Horwood *et al.*, 2021). It posits that fulfilling these needs determines the quality of one's motivation (Gagné and Deci, 2005). These assumptions have been further extended to contend that it is the extent of autonomous internalization linked with the motivation that makes a difference (Liu *et al.*, 2011). Building on the SDT, Vallerand *et al.* (2003) argue that harmonious passion emerges through the process of autonomously internalizing an activity

into one's identity, whereby individuals volitionally consider work as crucial to their identities due to the work characteristics (e.g. the work being meaningful or challenging).

Of particular relevance in current inquiry is a tenet of the SDT in terms of how to promote autonomous motivation by fulfilling fundamental needs for competence, autonomy and relatedness (Deci and Ryan, 2014). Partaking in an activity that satisfies these needs is likely to influence individuals to autonomously internalize the activity into their identity and develop a harmonious passion (Vallerand *et al.*, 2003). An SDT premise entails the salient role of contextual factors in impeding or fulfilling basic needs (Deci and Ryan, 2014) and ones' perceptions of the context are central to their passion (Ho *et al.*, 2018). Building on these SDT premises, this study next explains how the factor of HR flexibility, which can meet such basic needs, can facilitate harmonious passion and in turn activate citizen-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors.

HR flexibility and citizen-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors

From Bettencourt *et al.*'s (2005) view, citizen-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors can be defined as individuals' prosocial behaviors that associate their organization with its citizen-clients in forms of internal influence, external representation and service delivery. To fulfill a boundary-spanning role, members can engage in internal influence behavior by generating and sharing initiatives, and influencing colleagues to generate initiatives in relation to service delivery (Bayighomog and Arashi, 2019; Bettencourt *et al.*, 2005). They represent their organization to outsiders (including clients) and promote its image and products or services (Bettencourt *et al.*, 2005). They also demonstrate their boundary-spanning role by providing service in a courteous, responsible and flexible fashion (Parasuraman *et al.*, 2020).

HR flexibility is defined as the degree to which HRs of an organization possess skill and behavioral repertoires, as well as the degree to which the necessary HRM practices can be built and implemented in a timely manner to enhance the flexibility in such HRs (Way *et al.*, 2015, 2018). HR flexibility is further viewed as a dynamic organizational capability (Sekhar *et al.*, 2016) encompassing: (1) HRs who possess skill flexibility and behavioral flexibility and (2) the HR practices employed to effectively maximize such flexibility in HRs (Bhattacharya *et al.*, 2005).

Guided by the SDT, HR flexibility comprising skill flexibility, behavioral flexibility and HR practice flexibility can be expected to shape employees' citizen-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors. Skills flexibility indicates potential alternative uses where an employee's skills can be applied (Wright and Snell, 1998). Skill flexibility reflects competence to produce output streams for current and potential alternative requirements (Bhattacharya *et al.*, 2005). Employees with skill flexibility anticipate the need for future skills, display learning motivation for new approaches to tasks and view each event taking place inside the organization as a learning opportunity (Stokes *et al.*, 2015). Therefore, such employees can fulfill their needs for competence, control over work (with a broad repertoire of skills) and relatedness (through motivation to learn with and from others), which can motivate them not only to fulfill their in-role duties but also to go beyond their roles to contribute to the organization (Deci and Ryan, 2014). Consequently, employees with skill flexibility can fulfill their role in delivering services to citizens. Service delivery can also be accomplished since skill flexibility can enable employees to be responsive and adaptive in serving customers (Lepak *et al.*, 2003). Furthermore, with learning motivation and a broad repertoire of skills (Stokes *et al.*, 2015; Way *et al.*, 2018), employees can amplify and use skills to perform beyond the requirements of their work roles such as generating initiatives for service improvement (i.e. internal influence) and promoting the organization and its services (i.e. external representation) as forms of customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors.

Employee behavioral flexibility alludes to the degree to which they possess a broad repertoire of behavioral scripts which they can adapt under various conditions (Bhattacharya *et al.*, 2005). Rather than adhering to existing service procedures, members high in behavioral flexibility can adapt and demonstrate appropriate behavioral repertoires in line with situation-specific demands (Do *et al.*, 2016), as well as respond to previously unknown situations beyond their work roles (Bhattacharya *et al.*, 2005). Consequently, behavioral flexibility enables variation to emerge (Do *et al.*, 2016), which is a competence beneficial to generating service initiatives (i.e. internal influence) and promoting services (i.e. external representation) in citizen-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors.

HR practice flexibility alludes to the degree to which HR practices can be adapted and adopted in diverse situations, as well as the pace at which these adaptations and applications occur (Bhattacharya *et al.*, 2005). HR practice flexibility can provide employees with opportunities to develop and use a broad set of skills and behavioral scripts for adaptation (Ubeda-García *et al.*, 2017). Hence, HR practice flexibility can serve as a contextual factor that can meet employees' need for competence, autonomy, and relatedness since such opportunities not only enhance employees' skills and behavioral scripts (Way *et al.*, 2018), control over work and situations in interactions with customers (Do *et al.*, 2016) but also form connections with others by learning from them (Stokes *et al.*, 2015). Through the SDT lens, such a contextual factor can motivate them to engage in work duties and contribute to the organization (Deci and Ryan, 2014). Therefore, working under HR practice flexibility, public sector employees are motivated to deliver and promote services to citizens (i.e. service delivery and external representation) as well as use their broad set of skills and behavioral scripts (Tretiakov *et al.*, 2023) to improve and innovate services (i.e. internal influence). Additionally, being provided opportunities to enhance and use various skills and behavioral scripts through HR practice flexibility (Ubeda-García *et al.*, 2017), employees feel a stronger bond with the organization, experience more satisfaction of relatedness need and thus contribute more to the organization through promoting its image (external representation). In other words, HR practice flexibility can shape behaviors beyond the boundaries of their work, such as internal influence, external representation and service delivery. Taken together, we postulate the following hypotheses:

- H1. HR flexibility is positively related to public sector employees' citizen-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors in forms of internal influence (H1a), external representation (H1b) and service delivery (H1c).

Harmonious passion as a mediator

Passion alludes to an intense desire or inclination toward an activity that individuals are interested in, find significant, and invest their resources in. Job passion is defined as a job attitude encompassing an intense liking for an activity (affective element) and the perceived magnitude and meaning of the activity (cognitive element) (Ho *et al.*, 2011). These elements are not found concurrently in other job-related attitudes (Ho *et al.*, 2011). Harmonious passion, a form of work passion, refers to individuals' view of their work as significant and their autonomous internalization of the work not due to any pressures, but due to its attributes (e.g. the challenging nature of the work) (Vallerand, 2015). Employees who are harmoniously passionate about an activity do not encounter conflict between it and other life facets (e.g. professional growth goals, values in life and family) (Gong *et al.*, 2020).

In the organizational setting, the SDT and SDT-based research suggest that both contextual support and individual competence play a pivotal role in influencing an individual's extent of harmonious passion (i.e. autonomous internalization) (Deci and Ryan, 2014; Vallerand, 2015). Contextual support offers individuals a sense of volition, self-determination and freedom from external pressures for thinking or behaving

(Ryan and Deci, 2000). The SDT also underscores that contextual factors play a crucial part in affecting basic needs (Deci and Ryan, 2014) and work passion (Ho *et al.*, 2018). Hence, by providing employees with opportunities to develop and use a broad set of skills and behavioral scripts for adaptation (Ubeda-García *et al.*, 2017; Way *et al.*, 2018), HR practice flexibility can serve as contextual support that enables employees to experience self-determination and autonomously internalize activities, thereby forming harmonious passion.

Additionally, as postulated in the SDT, individuals with high competence and autonomy (i.e. control over their work) are likely to organize actions based on interests and personal goals rather than constraints and controls, as well as seek and exploit opportunities for choice and self-determination (Deci and Ryan, 2014). In this sense, it is posited that employees with a broad set of skills and behavioral scripts are inclined to experience self-determination and choice, thereby autonomously internalizing activities and developing harmonious passion. Specifically, employees, who are high in skill and behavioral flexibility, possess a broad set of skills and behavioral scripts for adaptation (Stokes *et al.*, 2015). They have positive beliefs about themselves due to their ability to exhibit appropriate behavioral repertoires under different situations and produce outputs for potential alternative demands (Bhattacharya *et al.*, 2005). Besides, with a repertoire of skills for adaptation and flexibility, employees can have more control over their work (Halbesleben *et al.*, 2014). They also anticipate the need for future skills, display enthusiasm about learning and build relationships with others for learning and developing new competence (Stokes *et al.*, 2015). Differently expressed, through skill and behavior flexibility from HR practice flexibility, employees possess competence and autonomy in generating appropriate behavioral scripts in serving citizens as well as fulfill their needs for autonomy, competence and relatedness, which drive them to view their work as significant and autonomously internalize it, leading to harmonious passion in their work (Ho *et al.*, 2011).

Though the effect of HR flexibility on harmonious passion has not been established in the management literature, prior studies have had some indications for the HRM effects on work passion. Jan *et al.*'s (2021) study reported the effect of HRM practices on employees' harmonious passion. Chen *et al.* (2017) found a positive association between high-commitment HR practices with harmonious passion for work. In light of the above reasoning and some evidence, HR flexibility, which comprises skill and behavioral flexibility and HR practice flexibility (Way *et al.*, 2018), can be expected to nurture public sector employees' harmonious passion. The subsequent hypothesis is consequently formulated:

H2. HR flexibility is positively related to public sector employees' harmonious passion.

As posited in the SDT, with a form of autonomous internalization (e.g. harmonious passion) (Deci and Ryan, 2014; Vallerand *et al.*, 2003), individuals can self-determine and endorse activities in a manner that harmonizes with other facets of their lives, which enable them to concentrate on their activities, to be less prone to depletion of cognitive and affective resources and to experience positive outcomes such as positive affect, high cognitive engagement or high task performance (Ho *et al.*, 2011; Horwood *et al.*, 2021; Vallerand, 2015). With positive affect and high cognitive engagement, harmoniously passionate employees can effectively engage in behaviors within their roles as well as outside their job descriptions (Ho *et al.*, 2018). Individuals are also inclined to engage in prosocial behaviors when they experience positive affect (Kong and Li, 2018). Thus, harmoniously passionate employees are inclined to promote the organization's image and public services (i.e. external representation) as prosocial behavior beyond their work roles. Affective and cognitive resources that harmoniously passionate members build can also expand their thought-action repertoires (Ho *et al.*, 2011), which facilitate not only their performance within their roles (e.g. service delivery) but also their pursuit of unscripted courses of action (Fredrickson, 2001), leading to initiatives for improving services (i.e. internal influence). Positive affect and high cognitive engagement

stimulate employees to explore links between divergent thoughts, thereby generating novel solutions for service improvement (Isen, 2000; Liu *et al.*, 2011).

Moreover, since positive affect can be conducive to relation satisfaction and closeness with others, harmonious passion can contribute to employees' positive relations with colleagues (Ho *et al.*, 2018). Such positive relationships can nurture employees' learning from colleagues' feedback and inputs as well as collaboration with them, which can help effectively perform service delivery tasks as well as explore novel solutions to improve service delivery (i.e. internal influence). Positive interpersonal connections, which fulfill relatedness needs, can also promote actions beneficial for their organization (Chiniara and Bentein, 2016) such as in the form of promoting its image and services (i.e. external representation). Furthermore, due to personally endorsing work activities in a fashion that is in harmony with other facets of their life (Vallerand, 2015), harmoniously passionate employees are less likely to face conflicts between roles within and outside their work and invest resources in handling them (Ho *et al.*, 2018), and hence preserve more resources (e.g. time and energy) to reinvest in improving or promoting services.

Integrating the above reasoning, it is tenable that harmonious passion leads to generating service initiatives (internal influence), delivering services effectively and promoting services (external representation). In juxtaposition with hypothesis H2, we propose the role of harmonious passion as a mediation path that links HR flexibility to citizen-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors as in the ensuing hypothesis:

- H3. Harmonious passion mediates the positive link between HR flexibility and citizen-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors in the forms of internal influence (H3a), external representation (H3b) and service delivery (H3c).

Employee perceptions of normative public values as a moderator

Normative public values comprise individual rights (civil rights and property rights), representation (responsiveness to citizens) and equity (fair distribution of resources) (Pandey *et al.*, 2016). Guided by these public values, public sector employees place citizens center-stage and serve them responsibly to build relations with them and gain their trust (Pandey *et al.*, 2016). Citizens will develop trust in the governmental agencies and the government that care about their basic human rights such as justice and property ownership (Yousaf *et al.*, 2016). According to Yang and Pandey (2007), responsiveness and equity are vital in promoting citizen trust since these can enhance public service quality, satisfy citizens' needs and increase their feeling of being equally treated.

The SDT posits that individual self-regulation in response to a situation can be thwarted or facilitated by individual or contextual contingencies (Ryan and Deci, 2000). Stated differently, the effects of a situation on employee motivation can be contingent on individual or contextual factors. In addition to individual contingencies such as personality (Wu and Zhou, 2023) or independent self-construal (Kong and Ho, 2016) which have been examined in prior inquiries, values are important contingencies underscored in the SDT (Graves and Sarkis, 2018) but have been less investigated (Park *et al.*, 2018; Sun *et al.*, 2023). The SDT postulates that, in the face of a specific situation in the organization (e.g. HRM practices), different values may influence the process of shaping motivation among employees (Graves and Sarkis, 2018). Research has given attention not only to the predictive role of perceived workplace values (Park, 2023) but also to the interaction between values and contextual factors (Park *et al.*, 2018; Sun *et al.*, 2023). Research has revealed that values may enhance employees' perceptions of contextual factors in the organization, which further accentuates the effects of such contextual factors. For instance, Park *et al.* (2018) reported that reform values can further promote public sector employees' positive appraisal of flexible work systems, leading to the heightened impact of such systems on their job satisfaction.

Sun *et al.* (2023) observed the role of power distance value in moderating the influence of exploitative leadership on employees' harmonious passion for work. The SDT and such prior findings highlight the importance of employee perceptions of values as a moderator for contextual effects, which supports the proposition that employee perceptions of normative public values in the work environment may play a moderating role in enhancing employee perceptions of HR practice flexibility, which further influences employees to be more harmoniously passionate about serving citizens.

Specifically, with high perceptions of normative public values in the work environment, employees tend to have a better understanding of the public mission and public service goals of the organization (Pandey *et al.*, 2016). Thus, such employees are more inclined to use their skills and competence to catch sight of citizen demands and provide better services to citizens. They, hence, rely more on HR practice flexibility since it enables them to build and use a broad repertoire of behavioral scripts and skills, with which employees can be responsive and adaptive to customers' situation-specific demands and changes in their demands (Bhattacharya *et al.*, 2005; Lepak *et al.*, 2003), address citizen demands in a timely and fair manner, and serve them with respect for their civil rights (Pandey *et al.*, 2016). In other words, the effect of HR flexibility on harmonious passion for serving citizens will be more pronounced among employees with high perceptions of normative public values.

Additionally, normative public values increase employee bonds with the public organization, which enhances their motivation to contribute to the organization (Hui *et al.*, 2021). Therefore, employees with high rather than low perceptions of normative public values may view HR practice flexibility in a more positive light since a broad repertoire of behavioral scripts and skills that they acquire can help them make a further contribution to the organization by providing better services to citizens.

Conversely, with low perceptions of normative public values in the work environment, employees may be less motivated to improve services for citizens and thus are less inclined to use skill flexibility and behavioral flexibility for service enhancements. This leads to their less responsiveness to and reliance on HR practice flexibility, resulting in a less pronounced effect of HR flexibility on their harmonious passion. From the above reasoning, we can expect employee perceptions of normative public values as a moderator that accentuates the impact of HR flexibility on harmonious passion among employees:

- H4.* Employee perceptions of normative public values moderate the relationship between HR flexibility and employee harmonious passion such that the relationship is stronger when employee perceptions of normative public values are higher.

The hypothesis above, together with the postulation on the indirect link between HR flexibility and employees' citizen-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors via the mediating pathway of employees' harmonious passion, indicates that the indirect relationship between HR flexibility and employees' citizen-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors is contingent on the extent of employee perceptions of normative public values. We expect that HR flexibility promotes citizen-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors through harmonious passion, which is more likely to occur under conditions of high perceptions of normative public values. Under such conditions, employees' harmonious passion and, in turn, citizen-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors tend to be more influenced by HR flexibility than under conditions of low perceptions of normative public values:

- H5.* Employee perceptions of normative public values moderate the relationship between HR flexibility and employees' citizen-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors in forms of internal influence (H5a), external representation (H5b) and service delivery (H5c) through employee harmonious passion such that the relationship is stronger when employee perceptions of normative public values are higher.

Research methods

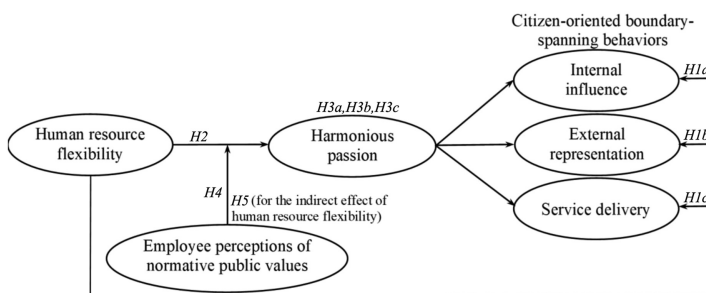
Sampling

The data were garnered from employees who belonged to governmental agencies in a major city in Vietnam. Six governmental agencies were randomly selected from each of the 24 districts of the city. We approached the heads of these agencies, explicated our academic purpose and solicited their voluntary participation. From the contact details of employees and their supervisors supplied by the agencies, the questionnaire link was emailed to them to invite their participation in tandem with the assurance of the confidentiality and anonymity of their responses.

Three data collection waves were conducted with a time lag of three months. To mitigate common method bias (CMB), we collected data for the independent and dependent constructs in different measurement waves (Podsakoff *et al.*, 2012). The first wave of measurement (T1) garnered data on HR flexibility and perceptions of normative public values from employees. In the second wave (T2), the data were collected for harmonious passion from employees. In the third measurement (T3), supervisors rated employees' citizen-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors.

At T1, 982 survey links were relayed to employees and 726 complete responses (response rate: 73.9%) were collected. At T2, 427 complete responses (response rate: 58.8%) were obtained from employees who partook in T1. At T3, among 144 survey links that had been distributed to supervisors, 102 complete responses (response rate: 70.8%) were obtained from supervisors. These participants belonged to 102 agencies. A total of 187 employees (43.8%) were female. Employees' mean age was 36.74 years ($SD = 7.52$), and their mean tenure with organization was 7.45 years ($SD = 3.96$).

Due to the existence of participants in the sample who failed to respond to survey questionnaires, it is crucial to test non-response bias (Green *et al.*, 2006). Non-response bias is presumably nonexistent if there exist no differences in the variables between the survey waves (Lambert and Harrington, 1990). Following Green *et al.* (2006), one-way ANOVA was employed to compare participants between the survey waves, which indicated no differences in the study variables ($p > 0.05$). We also found no difference in the study variables by comparing early respondents (i.e. responding to initial requests) and late respondents (i.e. responding to follow-up requests after two weeks), demonstrating that non-response bias was not a concern in the dataset.



Source(s): Created by author

Figure 1.
Research model

Measures

The measurement items (1 = “strongly disagree”, 5 = “strongly agree”, unless otherwise designated) were translated into Vietnamese through the lens of Schaffer and Riordan’s (2003) back translation approach. HR flexibility was gauged through Way *et al.*’s (2015) 21-item instrument (e.g. “Your agency’s current training process enables employees to learn new/different work activities”). This scale demonstrated an acceptable internal consistency reliability in Way *et al.*’s (2015) work of the original scale (Cronbach’s alpha [α] = 0.82) and other works (e.g. α = 0.72 [Way *et al.*, 2018]). Employee perceptions of normative public values were gauged through three items from Pandey *et al.* (2016). Employees were asked to rate the salience of public values including equity (a fair allocation of resources), representation (responsiveness to all citizens) and individual rights (civil rights, property rights) in making major decisions about public services in their agency (1 = “of little importance”; 5 = “extremely important”) (e.g. “How important is representation (responsiveness to all citizens) in making major decisions about public services in your agency?”). This scale exhibited a strong internal consistency reliability in prior inquiries (e.g. α = 0.86 [Luu *et al.*, 2022]). Citizen-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors were examined through items adapted from Bettencourt *et al.* (2005), comprising four items for internal influence (e.g. “Contributes many ideas for citizen promotions and communication”), four items for external representation (e.g. “Says good things about the organization to others”) and five items for service delivery (e.g. “Regardless of circumstances, exceptionally courteous and respectful to citizens”). The internal consistency reliability of the above dimensions of this scale was reported acceptable in Bettencourt *et al.*’s (2005) work of the original scale (α = 0.94, 0.90, 0.91, respectively) and other works (e.g. α = 0.80, 0.85, 0.85, respectively [Bayighomog and Arashi, 2019]). Harmonious passion was assessed through seven items from Vallerand *et al.* (2003) (e.g. “My work allows me to live memorable experiences”). The internal consistency reliability of this scale was found acceptable in Vallerand *et al.*’s (2003) work of the original scale (α = 0.79) and other works (e.g. α = 0.85 [Khan *et al.*, 2023]). This research controlled for employees’ age, gender, education and organizational tenure.

Data analytic strategy

By virtue of the nested nature of the data within agencies, this research adopts a 2-1-1 model (Preacher *et al.*, 2011) with the influence of a level 2 variable (HR flexibility) on level 1 outcome variables (citizen-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors) mediated by a level 1 variable (harmonious passion). Multilevel structural equation modeling (MSEM) was conducted through MPlus 7.2 to appraise indirect effects and mitigate the conflation of the level 1-level 2 nexus (Preacher *et al.*, 2011). Following Hofmann *et al.* (2000), we first group-mean centered all level 1 (i.e. employee-level) variables (i.e. harmonious passion, citizen-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors and control variables) to partial out level 2 (i.e. agency-level) variance and avoid conflating level 1 and level 2 variability. We then centered level 2 aggregates (see discussion on aggregation later) and added them to model the effect of level 2 variables. A Monte Carlo 20,000-replication test was employed to test the significance of indirect effects through confidence intervals (CIs) (Menges *et al.*, 2017). We calculated the interaction term and plotted the conditional effect of the predictor on the outcome at high (1 SD above the mean) and low (1 SD below the mean) levels of the moderator.

Results

Common method bias (CMB)

Following Podsakoff *et al.*’s (2012) recommendations, our study addressed potential CMB through procedural and statistical treatments. As procedural treatments, participants’

confidentiality and anonymity were ensured, the data for independent, mediating and dependent variables were collected in three different waves, and the data were collected from two different sources. Nonetheless, as HR flexibility, employee perceptions of normative public values and harmonious passion were assessed by employees (i.e. the same source of participants), we further statistically checked if the data were affected by CMB. First, we utilized the marker variable technique (Lindell and Whitney, 2001) by adding “fashion consciousness” (i.e. the importance that one attaches to being fashionably dressed) as a marker variable to the survey questionnaire due to no theoretical relevance of this marker to other constructs. This marker variable has been used in prior studies (e.g. S Wang *et al.*, 2021). When the marker was eliminated, all significant zero-order correlations remained significant, which revealed that the dataset was not affected by CMB. Second, we conducted the full collinearity test proposed by Kock (2015) and found that all variance inflation factors (VIFs) were under the 3.3 threshold (Kock, 2015). Third, the significant interactive effect further indicated that CMB was too weak to deflate it (Siemsen *et al.*, 2010). These statistical results indicated that CMB was not an issue for our dataset.

Aggregation

We assessed between-group variances by computing intra-class correlations 1 (ICC1s), ICC2s and rwg (Rho-within group agreement) values for HR flexibility and employee perceptions of normative public values. ICC1s for HR flexibility and employee perceptions of normative public values were 0.17 and 0.22, respectively, while their ICC2s were 0.69 and 0.73, respectively. These values were greater than James’s (1982) median value of 0.12 for ICC1 and Glick’s (1985) ICC2 threshold of 0.60. The r_{wg} average parameter was 0.74 [0.69, 0.82] for HR flexibility and 0.77 [0.72, 0.86] for employee perceptions of normative public values, exceeding Klein *et al.*’s (2000) threshold of 0.70. These variances were supportive of multilevel assessment.

Measurement models

The fit between the model and the data was decent ($\chi^2/df = 325.38/174 = 1.87$; Tucker–Lewis Index (TLI) = 0.95; incremental fit index (IFI) = 0.95; comparative fit index (CFI) = 0.96; standardized root mean residual (SRMR)_{within} = 0.052; SRMR_{between} = 0.073; root mean square error of approximation (RMSEA) = 0.049 (90% CI [0.042, 0.054])) and better than the fits of the alternative models built by merging constructs (Table 1). This was supportive of discriminant validity. It was further confirmed as each construct’s correlations with the other constructs were surpassed by its square root of the average variance extracted (AVE) (Table 2) (Fornell and Larcker, 1981) and the heterotrait-monotrait ratios varied from 0.14 to 0.72, under Kline’s (2011) criterion of 0.85.

Hypothesis estimation

As Table 3 demonstrates, HR flexibility exhibited a statistically significant and positive association with employees’ internal influence ($B = 0.34, p < 0.01$), external representation ($B = 0.25, p < 0.01$) and service delivery ($B = 0.29, p < 0.01$), in support of hypotheses H1a, H1b and H1c.

The results indicated that HR flexibility was positively and significantly linked with harmonious passion ($B = 0.31, p < 0.01$), lending credence to hypothesis H2. Hypothesis H3 postulates the mediating pathway of harmonious passion behind the positive connections between HR flexibility and the components of citizen-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors. Harmonious passion was significantly and positively linked with employees’ internal influence ($B = 0.42, p < 0.001$), external representation ($B = 0.27, p < 0.01$) and service

Table 1.
Comparison of
measurement models

Model	χ^2	df	$\Delta\chi^2$	TLI	IFI	CFI	SRMR within	SRMR between	RMSEA	RMSEA confidence interval
Hypothesized six-factor model	325.38	174		0.95	0.95	0.96	0.052	0.073	0.049	(0.042, 0.054)
Five-factor model: HR flexibility and employee perceptions of normative public values combined	410.61	179	85.23**	0.94	0.93	0.93	0.061	0.085	0.065	(0.058, 0.070)
Four-factor model: HR flexibility, employee perceptions of normative public values and harmonious passion combined	453.79	183	128.41**	0.91	0.92	0.91	0.075	0.098	0.079	(0.073, 0.085)
Three-factor model: HR flexibility, employee perceptions of normative public values, harmonious passion and internal influence combined	491.42	186	166.04**	0.89	0.89	0.90	0.091	0.107	0.093	(0.087, 0.098)
Two-factor model: HR flexibility, employee perceptions of normative public values, harmonious passion, internal influence and external representation combined	535.86	188	210.48**	0.86	0.85	0.84	0.109	0.121	0.112	(0.103, 0.118)
One-factor model: All variables combined	601.19	189	275.81**	0.77	0.78	0.78	0.126	0.146	0.128	(0.121, 0.134)
Note(s): ** $p < 0.01$										
Source(s): Created by author										

Variables	Mean	SD	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	CCR	AVE
1 Employee age	31.74	7.53	...											
2 Employee gender			0.01	...										
3 Employee education			0.04	0.02	...									
4 Employee organizational tenure	6.45	3.91	0.06	0.05	0.02									
5 HR flexibility	3.63	0.47	0.02	0.04	0.07	...								
6 Harmonious passion	3.81	0.59	0.03	0.06	0.05	0.02	(0.85)						0.84	0.72
7 Internal influence behavior	4.19	0.65	0.07	0.05	0.06	0.05	0.32**	(0.79)					0.81	0.62
8 External representation behavior	3.92	0.54	0.04	0.03	0.05	0.03	0.36***	0.43***	(0.84)				0.86	0.70
9 Service delivery behavior	4.14	0.61	0.06	0.07	0.05	0.04	0.27**	0.29**	0.22*	(0.82)			0.80	0.67
10 Employee perceptions of normative public values	3.57	0.58	0.05	0.04	0.07	0.02	0.30**	0.35***	0.29***	0.26**	(0.87)		0.83	0.75
							0.17*	0.24*	0.21*	0.19*	0.25*	(0.80)	0.79	0.64

Note(s): CCR = Composite construct reliability, AVE = Average variance extracted
 Values in parentheses display the square root of the average variance extracted
 Standardized correlations reported * $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$
Source(s): Created by author

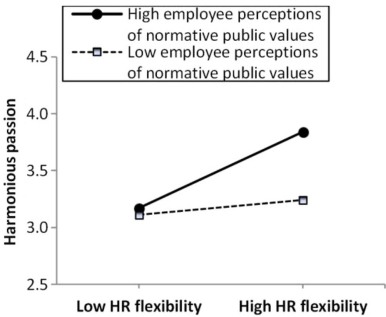
Table 2.
Correlation matrix

Table 3.
Path results

Hypothesis	Description of path	Unstandardized path coefficient	Conclusion
<i>Direct relationships</i>			
H1a	HR flexibility → Internal influence	0.34** (0.12)	Supported
H1b	HR flexibility → External representation	0.25** (0.08)	Supported
H1c	HR flexibility → Service delivery	0.29** (0.11)	Supported
H2	HR flexibility → Harmonious passion	0.31** (0.14)	Supported
	Harmonious passion → Internal influence	0.42*** (0.10)	Supported
	Harmonious passion → External representation	0.27** (0.09)	Supported
	Harmonious passion → Service delivery	0.32** (0.11)	Supported
<i>Indirect relationships</i>			
H3a	HR flexibility → Harmonious passion → Internal influence	0.13** (0.08) [95% CI = 0.07, 0.43]	Supported
H3b	HR flexibility → Harmonious passion → External representation	0.08* (0.05) [95% CI = 0.03, 0.31]	Supported
H3c	HR flexibility → Harmonious passion → Service delivery	0.09** (0.06) [95% CI = 0.02, 0.37]	Supported
<i>Interactive relationship</i>			
H4	HR flexibility × Employee perceptions of normative public values → Harmonious passion	0.22* (0.09)	Supported

Note(s): * $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$. Standard errors are presented in parentheses
Source(s): Created by author

Figure 2.
Moderating the role of employee perceptions of normative public values



Source(s): Created by author

(simple slope = 0.67, $p < 0.05$) than at its low levels (simple slope = 0.13, $p = 0.08$). These results were in support of hypothesis H4 vis-à-vis the moderating effect of employee perceptions of normative public values on the HR flexibility-harmonious passion linkage.

When employee perceptions of normative public values were at high levels, the indirect effect of HR flexibility on employees' internal influence through harmonious passion was significant (estimate = 0.11; SE = 0.06, 95% CI [0.05, 0.29] excluding 0, $p < 0.01$). HR flexibility also indicated a significant indirect effect on employees' internal influence (estimate = 0.02; SE = 0.01, 95% CI [0.01, 0.13] not including 0, $p < 0.05$) when employee perceptions of normative public values were at low levels. A significant difference was observed between the two indirect effects (estimate = 0.09 with 95% CI [0.04, 0.32] not straddling zero). Likewise, the indirect effects of HR flexibility on employees' external representation through harmonious passion at high and low levels of employee perceptions of normative public values were 0.07 (SE = 0.04; 95% CI = [0.03, 0.25]; $p < 0.05$) and 0.01 (SE = 0.01; 95% CI = [-0.05, 0.09]; $p > 0.10$), respectively. A significant difference was found between the two indirect effects (estimate = 0.06 with 95% CI [0.02, 0.18] not including zero). The indirect effects of HR flexibility on employees' service delivery via harmonious passion at high and low levels of employee perceptions of normative public values were 0.10 (SE = 0.05; 95% CI = [0.06, 0.34]; $p < 0.01$) and 0.04 (SE = 0.02; 95% CI = [0.02, 0.15]; $p < 0.05$), respectively. A significant difference was observed between the two indirect effects (estimate = 0.06 with 95% CI [0.01, 0.22] excluding zero). These results were in support of hypothesis H5 vis-à-vis the moderating role of employee perceptions of normative public values for the indirect nexus between HR flexibility and citizen-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors in forms of internal influence (H5a), external representation (H5b) and service delivery (H5c) via harmonious passion.

Conclusion

Our results support hypotheses H1a, H1b and H1c on the positive associations between HR flexibility and the three components of citizen-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors. We found evidence for hypothesis H2 regarding the positive link between HR flexibility and harmonious passion as well as hypotheses H3a, H3b and H3c vis-à-vis the mediation path of harmonious passion for the links between HR flexibility and citizen-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors. Furthermore, the results voice support for hypotheses H4 and H5, respectively, on the role of employee perceptions of normative public values as a moderator that strengthens the effect of HR flexibility on employees' harmonious passion as well as the indirect effect of HR flexibility on citizen-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors through harmonious passion.

Discussion

Research implications

This inquiry contributes to the extant knowledge in various facets. First, the current study advances the management literature by extending the concept of customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors to the public sector as well as identifying the effect of HR flexibility on citizen-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors of public sector employees. Albeit citizen-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors have not been explored in the management literature, our findings are partially consistent with previous studies that have reported the links between HRM and citizenship behavior in general (e.g. Cesário and Magalhães, 2017; Mostafa *et al.*, 2015). Nonetheless, through unmasking HR flexibility as a precursor for citizen-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors, this study contributes to the literature that has not examined HR flexibility as an antecedent but mainly focused on contextual antecedents around manager/organizational support or fairness such as

leadership (Bayighomog and Arasli, 2019), perceived organizational support (Wang *et al.*, 2022) or organizational justice (Bettencourt *et al.*, 2005) for customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors.

Second, our results unveil that HR flexibility activates citizen-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors through fueling their harmonious passion. These findings differentiate the current study from the extant literature that has concentrated on mediation mechanisms such as work engagement (Bal and De Lange, 2015), self-efficacy (Luu, 2016) and employability (Xu *et al.*, 2023) for the effects of flexible HRM systems. The current work thus contributes to the literature by delving into the mediating role of harmonious passion as a form of autonomous internalization rather than competence (e.g. self-efficacy and employability skills) or positive state of mind (e.g. work engagement). Our study also extends the stream of passion research by adding HR flexibility as a new element to the fledgling body of contextual precursors of harmonious passion, which is confined to group/supervisor autonomy support, leadership or high-commitment HR practices (Chen *et al.*, 2017; Ho *et al.*, 2018; Liu *et al.*, 2011; Sun *et al.*, 2023). It also lends further support for the SDT premise in terms of the pivotal role of a social context (e.g. HR practice flexibility) in stimulating individuals to autonomously internalize activities.

Third, irrespective of a growing interest among researchers in normative public values (Luu, 2022; Pandey *et al.*, 2016) as well as the SDT emphasis on the contingent role of values in the process of shaping motivation among individuals in face of a specific organizational situation (Graves and Sarkis, 2018), less scholarly attention has been given to the moderation mechanism of employee perceptions of normative public values behind the HRM effects (Cheewakoset *et al.*, 2023; Xu *et al.*, 2023). The current inquiry contributes to the literature by addressing a call for more inquiries into the moderating role of employee perceptions of normative public values (Luu, 2022). By examining this moderator, it also distinguishes itself from prior works that have concentrated on moderators such as organizational identity (Xu *et al.*, 2023), psychological capital (Cheewakoset *et al.*, 2023), or inclusive leadership (Zhang *et al.*, 2023) underlying the influence of flexibility HRM systems. It further supports the SDT premise on the salience of contingencies underlying a contextual effect on activating an individual's motivation. The current result indicates that employee harmonious passion is best realized by public sector employees who (1) work under HR practices that help them build a broad set of skills and behavioral scripts for flexibility and adaptation and (2) are exposed to normative public values.

Implications for practice

Our results present some practical implications. Since HR flexibility was found to activate citizen-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors, HR flexibility should be built in public organizations. Specifically, the selection process should assess candidates' skills to adapt and perform different roles in various situations. Training programs should be flexibly adapted to arm employees with new skills to perform new or different work aspects in response to different contingencies. Employees should be trained on how to adapt to deal with diverse client types, diverse demands and diverse service delivery situations. Through HR flexibility, employees can develop harmonious passion for serving citizens as well as acquire the knowledge and skills necessary for the generation of novel solutions for public service improvement and promotion.

The current study further reveals the moderating effect of employee perceptions of normative public values underlying the effects of HR flexibility. Hence, public organizations should provide communication programs to shape or reinforce employees' awareness of normative public values including civil rights, equity and representation. When valuing these values and feeling encouraged to enact them, employees are more

Limitations and pathways for future research

Several limitations are acknowledged in the present study. First, its use of self-report data and a time-lagged research design might engender CMB. While this research found CMB not to be a major concern through the marker variable test, the interactive effect test and the multi-source data collection, future research should further diminish CMB through a cross-lagged approach (Kasl and Jones, 2003). Moreover, the causal relationships of the studied variables, which could not be derived through a time-lagged approach, should be further explored through experimental or cross-lagged research designs.

Second, the generalizability of the current findings might be limited by a single cultural context of the study. Studies of HR flexibility have engaged with some Western contexts such as North America (Way *et al.*, 2018), Australia, New Zealand (Tretiakov *et al.*, 2023) or Spain (Ubeda-Garcia *et al.*, 2017) as well as some non-Western contexts such as India (Sekhar *et al.*, 2016) or Taiwan (Do *et al.*, 2016). Accordingly, future research is encouraged to delve into the effectiveness of HR flexibility in more Western and non-Western contexts. Besides, extant inquiries of HR flexibility have tended to concentrate on some sectors such as IT (Do *et al.*, 2016; Sekhar *et al.*, 2016; Tretiakov *et al.*, 2023) and hospitality (Ubeda-Garcia *et al.*, 2017). More research in settings beyond these sectors as well as in mixed industries should be conducted to enhance the generalizability of the current findings.

Third, while research has revealed the predictive role of high-performance work systems or high-commitment HR practices for employee performance outcomes through autonomous motivation or harmonious passion (Chen *et al.*, 2017; Jaiswal and Tyagi, 2020), future works should comparatively analyze the effects of HR flexibility versus these two forms of HR practices on harmonious passion and in turn employee outcomes. Additionally, since our research model is incapable of accounting for every underlying mechanism for the linkage between HR flexibility and citizen-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors, future research should consider other mediators and moderators. When members possess a broad set of skills and behavioral scripts for adaptation, role breadth self-efficacy may emerge. Therefore, further research should investigate the mediating role of this variable. Future studies can also examine skill flexibility and behavioral flexibility as mediation paths underlying the effects of HR practices. Furthermore, since idiosyncratic deals (i-deals), viewed as individually negotiated agreements between employees and the employer for work flexibility, can add further flexibility and adaptability to members (Rofcanin *et al.*, 2017), i-deals may play a moderation role in the effects of HR flexibility on citizen-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors on a new research path.

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